

Charging for the invisible work: travel, delivery, storage, extras

Clients pay for what they can see, the shoot and the edit, so the work they can't see becomes free by default. Four things go missing most: travel time, raw footage delivery, storage, and the extras that creep in on site. The fix is four lines on the quote, before the job starts, with wording the client reads as a rule rather than a surprise. A cost stated early is a rule. A cost raised late is a fight.

Why does the work the client never sees end up free?

The work the client never sees ends up free because nobody quoted it. You give it away by default, not by decision, and once the job is under way it feels too late to bring it up.

A video business owner I work with took a job with a lot of travel. Flights, hire car, nights away, days of his life moving between locations around the country. When it came time to invoice, he froze. Somewhere along the way he'd realised he had never once mentioned charging for the travel time, and now it felt too late to raise it. So he ate it. Days of work, given away, because sitting in a car didn't feel like work.

That's the trap, and almost every video owner falls into it. Clients pay for what's visible. The shoot, the edit, the thing they can watch. So that's what you quote, and everything else quietly becomes free. You hand over three terabytes of footage because pressing upload doesn't feel like a service. You hold the files for a year because the drive is sitting there anyway. You stay the extra half day because you're already on site. And because you never put a price on any of it, raising one later feels like a money grab, so you swallow it.

Over a year, the invisible work is where a serious chunk of your margin disappears. It isn't one big leak. It's a hundred small ones. A day-rate quote makes it worse, because a day rate prices the days on set and in the suite, and everything around them (the planning calls, the transfers, the travel, the client management) is real work with no line. The owner absorbs it, quietly, on every job.

Most owners can do the arithmetic. What stops them is permission: they don't believe they're allowed to charge for these things. You are. This guide gives you the wording.

How to charge for the invisible work: the method, step by step

The method is four lines on every quote, each with fixed wording, plus one paragraph that says what's included and what's extra. Add them to your quote template once and they're there before every job starts.

1. **Put travel time on the quote as its own line.** Not the fuel, the time. A day in a car or an airport is a day you can't earn anywhere else, so it's billed against your day rate. The trigger is 60 minutes each way: inside that, travel is part of the job; beyond it, it's a half day. Done looks like: the travel line is on the quote, with the trigger, before the client has seen a price.

Copy and paste: the travel line

Travel and transit beyond 60 minutes each way: billed at half our day rate (\$[half day rate]), as its own line.

2. **Price raw footage delivery as a product.** The client wants the raw files. That's hours of organising and upload, a drive, postage or an upgraded storage plan. One owner used to hand over terabytes for free: upload time, drives, postage, his weekend. The day he realised he was allowed to charge, he put one line on the quote, raw footage organisation and transfer, \$1,450, and the client paid it without blinking. The line goes on the quote with the volume and the price, not on the final invoice.

Copy and paste: the raw footage line

Raw footage organisation and transfer ([X] TB): \$[Y], as its own line.

3. **Put a term and a price on storage.** You're holding terabytes for months after the job, which makes you a free archive service for people who'd pay for cloud storage without thinking. Twelve months is the term. After that the project is archived or released, and the client knows which. The 12-month term also gives you a reason to get back in touch a year later. Done looks like: a storage line with a term, and a diary note for month eleven.

Copy and paste: the storage line

Project archive and storage, 12 months: \$[Y] per project. After that, archived or released.

4. **Agree the extras before they happen.** The extra half day, the second location, the "while you're here". These are the absorbed extras, and the rule is simple: agreed before it happens, never discovered on the invoice. The line sits on the quote so the price exists before the ask. On the day, when the ask comes, you point at the line instead of inventing a number on the spot. You're done when the client has seen the half-day price before anyone is on site.

Copy and paste: the extras line

Additional half day on site: \$[Y]. Agreed before it happens, never discovered on the invoice.

5. **Add the included-and-extra paragraph under the quote total.** The four lines tell the client what the invisible work costs. The paragraph tells them where the edges are, so nothing arrives as a surprise. Every quote that leaves your business carries it.

Copy and paste: what's included and what's extra

This quote includes [the shoot days], [the deliverables], two rounds of revisions per deliverable, and travel within 60 minutes of [base]. Travel beyond that, raw footage delivery, and any additional time on site are priced above as their own lines and apply when they occur. Project archive and storage runs for 12 months from delivery. Anything not listed here is quoted separately before it's done.

The revision rounds in that paragraph have their own wording and their own three emails in **The three revision emails**. The rest of the job's edges are covered by **the scope checklist**.

What to say if the client asks why these lines are on the quote

Itemising up front reads as professional and clear. The petty version is the surprise charge six weeks in. Clients don't resent line items. They resent surprises.

If a client asks, answer it straight.

Copy and paste: the answer on the call

"Those lines are on every quote we send, so there are no surprises later. Three of them are conditional: travel only applies beyond an hour each way, the raw footage line only if you want the files, and the extra half day only if we need it on the day. In each case the price is already agreed. Storage applies to every project, so your files are held for twelve months after delivery."

A worked example

Here's the method on one job, in round numbers, using the day rate from the [pricing guide](#): \$2,100 a day, so a half day is \$1,050. A two-day shoot three hours' drive from base, staying overnight, and the client wants the raw footage. Three hours each way, so both legs clear the hour and each leg is billed as a half day. That's the travel line's rule; you set your own trigger and rate on your quote.

Before: everything below was done and none of it was invoiced. Six hours in the car, a weekend organising and uploading three terabytes, a year of holding the files, and a half day on site that crept in when the client asked for one more interview while the crew was there.

After: the same job with the four lines on the quote. The raw footage line is the figure from the story above. The others are round numbers against a round day rate.

Travel and transit beyond 60 minutes each way (half day out, half day back)	\$2,100
Raw footage organisation and transfer (3 TB)	\$1,450
Project archive and storage, 12 months	\$300
Additional half day on site (price on the quote, agreed on the day)	\$1,050
Invisible work, priced	\$4,900

In the four-section quote, travel and the extra half day sit in production, and delivery and storage sit in post-production. On the \$11,880 example quote in the pricing guide, that's \$4,900 the owner either invoices or absorbs. Multiply it by the number of jobs a year that involve travel or a raw handoff and you have the size of the leak.

The mistakes that undo it

The invisible work goes back to being free in five predictable ways.

- **Raising it mid-job.** The owner in the travel story had a day rate. What he didn't have was a travel line on the quote before the job began. Once the job is under way a new charge reads as a grab, and most owners swallow it rather than have the conversation. The only place this is easy is the quote.
- **Charging for the fuel and not the time.** Mileage covers the car. It doesn't cover the day you couldn't sell to anyone else. Travel is billed against the day rate.
- **Treating the upload as a courtesy.** Free delivery of raw footage means you worked a weekend for nothing. The hours are real, the drive costs money, and the client would pay the line if it were there.
- **Letting the half day be discovered on the invoice.** The extra time happened, so you bill it, and the client who never agreed to it pushes back hard. The price belongs on the quote, and the agreement happens before the extra time, not after it.
- **Holding the files with no term.** Storage with no end date is a free archive service. Twelve months, then archived or released.

The rule of thumb for the invisible work

If it costs you time or money, it's a line item. The benchmark: travel beyond 60 minutes each way at half the day rate, raw footage delivery priced per handoff, storage at 12 months per project, extra time on site agreed before it happens.

Hold yourself accountable

Which of these have you taken on or put in place recently?

- Your quote template carries the four invisible lines, with the wording filled in.
- The last job with travel beyond an hour each way had a travel line on the quote.
- The last raw footage handoff was priced before the files moved.
- The last extra half day on site was agreed, with a price, before it happened.

Your one move this week

What's the one thing you can commit to implementing this week? If you're not sure, start here.

Open your quote template and add the four lines today, even at a placeholder price. Then go back to your last job and add up the hours you spent on things the client never saw: travel, uploading, storage, the extra time on site. Put your day rate against those hours. That number is the raise you've been giving your clients for free, and the four lines are how it stops.

One thing executed every week creates 50 strategic moves a year.

Questions like these come up regularly on our weekly Elite Boardroom calls. If you'd like someone to hold you to account each week, and to learn from a group of peers who run video businesses too, [the Boardroom is for you](#).

Related tools and guides. [How to price a video project](#) (the day rate the travel and half-day lines are built from), [The scope checklist](#) (the six checks that keep the rest of the job paid), [Anatomy of a Profitable Quote](#), [The three revision emails](#), [Drop the scope, not the price](#), [Pricing Calculator](#).



The field guides show you how the system works. The Boardroom is where I look at your business with you, give you perspective and judgement on what to do next, and hold you to it every week.

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